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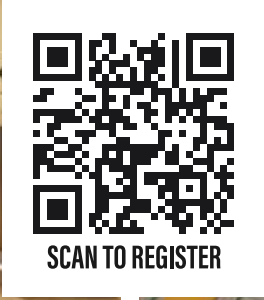


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THE HINDU

On Annamacharya trail

A temple in Tiruppudaimarudhur has a rare mural of the composer and his family **p2**

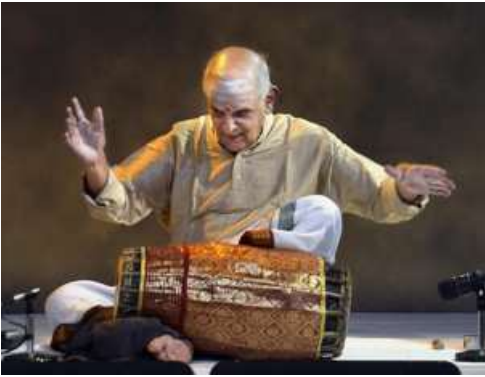
Ode to Pt. Ravi Shankar

An ensemble recreates the magic of the sitar legend's compositions **p3**



AN ICON OF SOUTH INDIAN CINEMA

B. Nagi Reddi's memoir by his son offers a peek into his life and works **p4**



The fourth edition of the Mahindra Percussion Festival, organised in association with *The Hindu*, turns the spotlight on diverse drumming styles

Neha Kirpal

India is a rhythmically diverse nation, where every region nurtures and practises its own percussive dialect. To unify this musical spirit, the Mahindra Percussion Festival, organised in association with *The Hindu*, returns to Bengaluru with its fourth edition on March 7 and 8.

Presenting a curated line-up of artistes across generations, regions and rhythmic expressions, the two-day festival celebrates legendary musicians and contemporary ensembles, besides putting the spotlight on percussion.

"Percussion has always been an integral part of India's musical culture. Through this festival, we aim to bring together artistes from across the country – each with a different identity, yet converging as one in India's evolved musical tradition. It is our attempt to reach out to the next generation," says Jay Shah, vice president and head of cultural outreach at the Mahindra Group.

A highlight of this edition is 'Nada Pravaham - Circle of Sound' – a collaboration between mridangam maestro Umayalpuram K. Sivaraman, along with formidable instrumentalists Ishaan Ghosh and Shravan Samsi.

"India is known as the land of chants, shlokas and rhythms. The opening act is a curated set with multi-generational Hindustani, Carnatic and Western classical artistes," says Ishaan.

"The festival not only

promotes our cultural legacy, but also caters to contemporary audience. This festival is unique because it is dedicated to percussion and brings together instrumentalists on a single platform," feels Sivaraman. According to Shravan, the festival also makes space for innovations in rhythm along with showcasing celebrated traditions.

Vocalist Mahesh Kale will strike an unusual note with 'Yatra,' which is a tribute to Maharashtra's bhakti culture. Percussionists will be the mainstay of this performance

too. "Rhythm is not just about sound, but also being in harmony with the inner rhythm. This defines 'Yatra' and the pulse of our devotional music. I feel this festival is one of the most apt platforms for this production," shares Mahesh.

The festival will also feature an all-women performance titled 'Women Who Drum'. It is a groundbreaking collective of women artistes, including Swarupa Ananth (tabla), Charu Hariharan (mridangam), Nush Lewis (harp), Amirthavarshini Manishankar (thavil), and Shalini Mohan (bass).

This ensemble includes the tabla, mridangam and harp. "It's amazing that the festival has decided to feature women percussionists who rarely get a chance to perform at such major events. The highlight of this ensemble is the collaborative and creative spirit," says Charu.

Nush and Swarupa can't agree more. The festival is sure to inspire many youngsters to pursue their musical passion. Apart from bringing to the fore the collective ability of different ensemble, it will also celebrate individual skill, says the duo.

Nanbargal Gramiya Kalai Kuzhu ensemble, Mylai M. Karthikeyan, Dholak Kaccha and Laxman Arvind are part of 'The Parai Awakens - Unreserved Live' by Praveen Sparsh. It highlights the festival's commitment to amplify every voice within the musical landscape. The act brings one of Tamil Nadu's oldest folk instruments into the mainstream through reinvention and reclamation.

Says Praveen: "I see music as existing in two broad forms – one led by lyrics that guide the listener through emotion and narrative, and the other,

instrumental, where the listener's imagination shapes the experience. Percussion takes this abstraction a step further. It invites both the artiste and the audience into a more open, immersive space of listening. In that sense, a festival dedicated exclusively to percussion becomes a rare blessing – for the artistes to express themselves freely, and for audiences to engage with rhythm in its most expansive form."

The festival will conclude with Grammy-nominated tabla artiste Bickram Ghosh's 'Drums of the East'. It bridges

Rhythm rendezvous



A mosaic of beats (Clockwise from left) Charu Hariharan; Swarupa Ananth; Praveen Sparsh; Bickram Ghosh; Umayalpuram Sivaraman; Ishaan Ghosh and Shravan Samsi. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Hindustani classical and contemporary music. Bickram conceived this presentation to celebrate the deep and spiritually charged rhythmic traditions and sounds of Bengal. The show layers tabla, electronic percussion and body drums. The ensemble also includes Gopal Barman on the sreekhhol; Ranjan De on the dhol; Gokul Dhaaki and team; and Abhisek Mallick on the electric sitar.

"Man discovered the beat before the note. At one point, communication happened through beats when language had not yet evolved. The importance of rhythm in human life is incalculable. If one simply looks at the difference between life and death, it is all about the heartbeat. Everything in this universe is set to rhythm, and being in rhythm is cyclic in nature, such as a 24-hour day, 365-day year and the Earth revolving around the sun. Percussion is healing and joy-giving, because a percussion instrument says a lot about a culture and where it hails from. This festival will be a kaleidoscope of rhythm and energies. It gives the audience an opportunity to see, learn and imbibe India's rhythmic gamut, which is increasing every day," believes Bickram Ghosh.

The Mahindra Percussion Festival will take place on March 7 and 8 at the Prestige Centre for Performing Arts, Bengaluru. Tickets on BookMyShow

Dance of the lens

Chennai-based visual documentor Ramya Sriram's fiery Theyyam photograph wins an award

Manasa Vijaylakshme C.

For Chennai-based photographer and avid traveller Ramya Sriram, capturing ritualistic forms on camera is not just a hobby, but a passion to document tradition and culture.

Ramya shot the Kandamar Kalam Theyyam in 2023 over eight hours in a small and crowded temple at Kannur in Kerala. She submitted it for the 'Capture in Motion' campaign of National Geographic. It

invited photographers to share powerful images of movements that conveyed stories, as part of its initiative to celebrate World Photography Day on August 19, 2025.

Her winning image captures the spirit of Theyyam, a ritualistic performance known for its intensity, fire and speed.

"I am delighted because I feel it is a recognition of my decade-long effort," says Ramya, whose photograph will be part of Nat Geo's calendar.

Theyyam is performed by men



who transform into deities. Wearing elaborate headgear and faces painted in vivid hues, they perform in shrines to the beats of the chenda and cymbals, and bless

devotees. The sacred ritual also includes walking on fire.

Ramya's journey with Theyyam began long before the contest. She

Winning frame (Left) The image of Kandamar Kalam Theyyam photographed by Ramya Sriram (below).

first travelled to Kerala post-COVID in 2021. In 2022, she began to gather information about Theyyam, the communities that perform it and temples where it is held.

"In many temples, women are not allowed near certain spaces. So, I make it a point to check with the temple authorities and family custodians before photographing," adds Ramya. She has also explored other ritualistic forms in North Kerala, sometimes venturing into dense forests.

Speaking about her award-winning photograph, Ramya



says, "When the performance began, there was chaos all around. Flames rose nearly 10 ft high. The performer had very little space to move. As the crowd surged, I was pushed to the ground near the burning coals. I was injured and had to leave. Out of the five frames that I shot, three were out of focus. Fortunately, two were good enough to be submitted for the contest."

Ramya, who describes herself as a visual storyteller dedicated to chronicling festivals, faith and human connection, also documents ritualistic performances such as Mayana Kollai and Kulasai Dasara in Tamil Nadu and Masan Holi in Varanasi. She has also photographed the Pushkar Camel Fair and the Maha Kumbh Mela besides heritage towns using both a camera and a drone. She hopes to compile her work into a book.



Painted histories

A mural at the Tiruppudaimarudur Narumponnathar Temple depicts saint-composer Annamacharya with wife Thimmakka and their son

Srikrishnan V.

Tiruppudaimarudhur, a village on the banks of the Tamiraparani river, is home to the revered Narumponnathar Shiva temple, a must-visit for anyone passionate about history. The temple boasts a five-tiered rajagopuram, with a narrow staircase that ascends to its apex. Each tier is adorned with stunning murals and wooden carvings that date to the Vijayanagara and Nayak periods. The paintings illustrate the sthalapurana of Tiruppudaimarudhur, events from Tiruvilaiyadal Puranam and Periyapuranam, as well as scenes from the *Ramayana*, the *Mahabharata* and *Valli Thirumanam*. The artwork also offers a glimpse into the socio-political and economic events of the time and an intricate imagery of the Venad-Nayak war, highlighting the temple’s historical significance.

S. Balusami, associate professor of Tamil at the

Madras Christian College, Chennai, has conducted an extensive research about Tiruppudaimarudhur paintings. He has concluded that these artworks vividly depict the ‘Tamiraparani battle’ of 1532 CE, fought between the armies of the Travancore king Bhoothala Veera Udaya Marthanda Varma and the Vijayanagara emperor Achyutadevaraya. Balusami identifies Dhalavai Ariyanatha Mudaliyar, the distinguished general of the Madurai Nayaks, as the visionary behind the commissioning of the paintings. He is also credited with establishing the shrine for Ariyanayaki amman at Tiruppudaimarudhur.

The timeline for the paintings is believed to be between 1532 and 1564 CE, post the Tamiraparani war of 1532 and preceding the pivotal battle of Talikotta in 1564, which marked the collapse of the Vijayanagara empire.

The vibrant paintings also portray a diverse array of musicians and dancers. Publications by Balusami and the Department of Museum



describe the musicians’ appearance, but don’t identify the individuals. However, one notable artwork that has historical significance is seen on the third level. It features two men, one holding a tambura and wearing the distinctive Kullayi cap and the other holding cymbals. They unmistakably identify as the revered saint-composer Annamacharya and his son Pedda Tirumalacharya, for it matches with the iconographic representation of other known sculptures of Annamacharya. The woman is Thimmakka, Annamacharya’s wife, the first woman Telugu poet.

Celebrated as the ‘Pada Kavitha Pithamaha’, Annamacharya lived between 1408 and 1503 CE and composed 32,000 keertanas. His profound legacy of creating sankeertanas dedicated to Swami Venkateswara was

continued by his descendants, notably his son Pedda Tirumalacharya, and his grandson Chinna Tirumalacharya, also a notable composer of sankeertana. The famous composition ‘Vandeham jagat vallabham’ is attributed to him.

In 1922, about 14,000 sankeertanas, along with several other literary works, were discovered in a chamber (Sankeertana Bhandagaram) within the Tirumala temple. The entrance to this repository features sculptures of Annamacharya and Pedda Tirumalacharya, symbolising their significant contributions to devotional music. This iconography also matches with the Tiruppudaimarudhur paintings. In Krishnapuram village near Tirunelveli, one can find a sculpture of Annamacharya at the Venkatachalapathy temple.

Back in time The painting inside the Tiruppudaimarudur temple; a statue of Pedda Tirumalacharya at Krishnapuram; and the Tiruppudaimarudur temple tower. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT & THE HINDU ARCHIVES



Initially it was difficult to identify the sculpture, but now a board identifies the sculpture as that of Annamacharya.

The timeline of Achyutadevaraya and Ariyanatha Mudaliyar and their connection with Krishnapuram and Tiruppudaimarudhur the sculptures and the paintings are of Annamacharya.

But more significant is the portrayal of Annamacharya’s wife, Thimmakka also known as Tirumalamma. Her remarkable work, ‘Subhadra Kalyanam’ comprising 1,170 padas, eloquently narrates the marriage of Arjuna and Subhadra. The work flows gently and the verses are suitable for singing. She has written it based on Nannayya’s Andhra Mahabaratam.

Thimmakka also adds a bit of humour to the exchanges between Krishna and Arjuna. Another notable aspect is that the sringara rasa is expressed from a woman’s point of view. Unlike the Vyasa and Nannayya versions of the Mahabharata, Thimmakka’s sees Arjuna visit Ahobilam, Tirumala, Kanchipuram and Srirangam during his pilgrimage, perhaps a pointer to the places she had visited.

One does wonder though as to why there is no sculpture of hers in Tirumala. Perhaps, she was not that famous at the time those sculptures were commissioned. The one in Tiruppudaimarudhur is precious because there appears to be no other known sculpture or painting of Thimmakka. And that is how an iconic Telugu poet ended up being celebrated in a village in Tamil Nadu far away from Tirumala.

Promising steps

Mahalakshmi Ravishankar conveyed well the viraha nayika’s yearning

Srividy

Under the auspices of Sri Parthasarathy Swamy Sabha, Mahalakshmi Ravishankar gave a solo performance at R.K. Swamy Auditorium. Having started her tutelage under Archana Mahesh, Mahalakshmi continued to train under Janane Sethunarayanan, a disciple of Anitha Guha.

Mahalakshmi commenced her performance with Thodayamangalam in Ragamalika, Talamalika.

Mahalakshmi brought out the pain and longing of the viraha nayika, who feels distressed due to the separation from her lord, in the Bhairavi varnam ‘Nandagopalanai vara cholladi sakhiye’ by Periyasami Theoran set to Adi tala. She brought out her devotion for Krishna in this piece. The sequence of theeramanams that embellish the varnam was executed effortlessly by the dancer.

Next in line was the all-time favourite ‘Chinnanajiru kiliye’ by Bharatiyar in ragamalika set to Tisra Adi. This is one of the famous verses by the Tamil poet, which have been interpreted differently by different dancers. Mahalakshmi recreated Anitha Guha’s choreography depicting vatsalya bhava, bringing out the unconditional love of a mother for her child.

She concluded her recital with a thillana by Poochi Srinivasa Iyengar, in raga Sankarabharanam and choreographed by Adyar Lakshman.

The orchestra, consisting of Hariprasad Kaniyal (vocals), Kalaarasan Ramanathan (violin), Ramshankar Babu (mridangam), and Janane Sethunarayanan (nattuvangam) enriched the performance.



Mahalakshmi Ravishankar. PHOTO: M. SRINATH

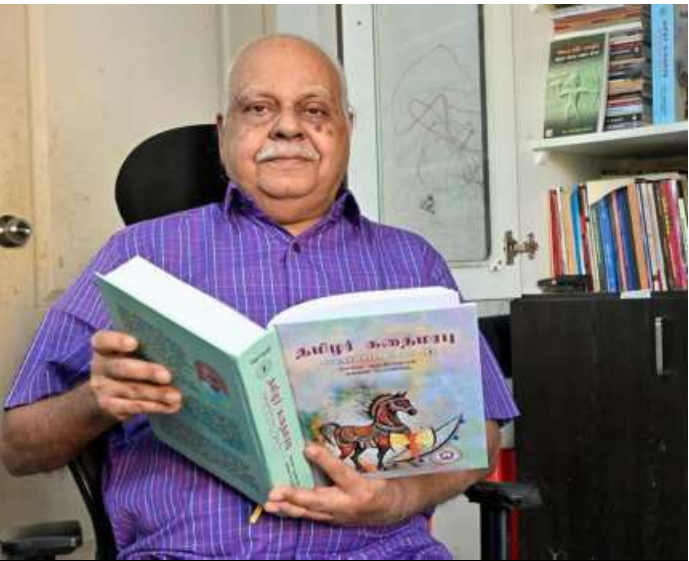
Suganthy Krishnamachari

Tamil storytelling is thousands of years old, with many folk tales becoming side stories in epics such as the *Silappadikaram* and *Manimekalai*,” says Prof. Aru Ramanathan, a Ph.D scholar in folk songs and former head of the Department of Folklore, Tamil University, Thanjavur. Ramanathan has authored more than 55 books. “In 1981, I decided to publish a compilation of all available folk ballads. The project was completed recently, with the help of my student P. Saktivel. The book is titled *Tamizhar Kathai Marabu-Kathai padalgal*,” says Ramanathan.

What is the difference between folk songs and folk ballads? “Folk songs are short, and do not necessarily contain a story. Short ballads are called *kurunkathai*. And ballads with more than 500 lines are called *nedunkathai*. Some have 30,000 lines. Most ballads, except some *kummi* ballads, are performed for an audience,” elaborates Ramanathan.

Temple worship has kept alive the ballad tradition through villupattu. “Villupattu ballads were mostly about temple deities. They began to be written down sometime in the 18th century, and in one village I found 18 copies of the Sudalai Madan ballad.”

“In the Kongu region, ballads are presented to the



A repository of music

Prof. Aru Ramanathan’s new compilation *Tamizhar Kathai Marabu-Kathai padalgal* traces the evolution of Tamil folk ballads

accompaniment of the percussion instrument udukkai. Kaniyan koothu artistes of Tirunelveli hold more than 35 ballads in their memory. In areas around Tiruchi, ballads are presented to the accompaniment of pambai. Therukkoothu, which has a significant ballad repertoire, is now performed mostly in Chennai, Chingleput, Tiruvannamalai, Dharmapuri,

Salem, Villupuram and Cuddalore. But there was a time when it was common in the Southern districts of Tamil Nadu too,” says Ramanathan. At a time when newspapers were not easily available in villages, ballads informed people of disasters such as train accidents and fires. “Tappe (a percussion instrument) was played when such ballads were presented. Often the lyrics of

Melodic archive (Left) Prof. Aru Ramanathan and (below) the book. PHOTOS: R. RAVINDRAN & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



these ballads were printed and sold where there was a large gathering of people,” he adds.

When did ballads originate? Scholar Vanamamalai says folk ballads began in the 14th century. But most were written from the 16th to early 20th century. *Ramappayyan Ammanai* was, perhaps, the earliest to be written (1623 - 1659 CE). “The *Ramayana* and the *Mahabharata* ballads must probably date earlier, but we are unable to determine the exact time period. The first printed ballads were *Chithiraputhira Nayanar Kathai* and *Amaravati Kathai*, published in 1868 by Kondalakan Pulavar. Till 1900, at least 65 ballads were published.”

Was any particular meter used for the verses? “Ballad writers used meters that would convey the core idea of a ballad. In *Desingurajan Kathai*, the meter suggests the galloping of a horse, which is apt, since the ballad is about Desingu’s heroism on the battlefield.”

Ramanathan points out that the ballad *Vellaikkaran Kathai*, shows the writer’s knowledge of geography, besides many other subjects. In *Vellaikkaran Kathai*, a Britisher (Parangidurai) asks carpenters to build a ship for him. For the flag post, he chooses a tree in which Senkidaikkaaran resides, thanks to a boon from Shiva. The ship is built in London and begins its journey from Dover Port reaching Kayankulam in Kerala, where it is loaded with various things. But as it proceeds on its return journey, Senkidaikkaaran takes the form of an eagle, shakes the ship, and overturns it. All the Englishmen on board die, and with the grace of Senkidaikkaaran they become gods.

“The ballad must have been written after 1869, because it mentions the Suez canal, which was opened in 1869. The ballad mentions 79 places that the ship visits such as Corsica, Sicily, Naples, Greece, Cyprus and Beirut. This ballad was written by Sivan Anainja Perumal Nadar’s son Muthayya Nadar of Pooviyoor, which is close to Kanyakumari. Folklorist A.N. Perumal records that even today, offerings are made in

Pooviyoor to Senkidaikkaaran and then to Vellaikaara sami (the Britishers on board the ship), showing that the ballad was not entirely imaginary. During worship, a man dances, peering through an imaginary telescope. He speaks a few sentences in English and mimics the shooting of the eagle. This work tells us the different kinds of wood that were used for building ships.”

Through ballads we learn that in some instances women, defying tradition, performed funeral rites for dead relatives. Some ballads show us how certain customs continued over the centuries. In *Purananuru* (verse 249), a widow covers the ground with cowdung paste, and then offers *pinda* for her dead husband. In the folk ballad *Kuruvi Paattu*, the female *kuruvi* also covers the ground with cow dung paste before offering *pinda* to its departed partner. “So we find a Sangam era practice continuing for many centuries,” says Ramanathan.

While studying the origin of folk deities, Ramanathan found that there were more temples for goddesses than male gods, because more women ended their lives or were killed. The perpetrators of injustice against women were afraid that the dead women would take revenge on them, and so promptly deified them as a form of atonement!

“Ballads are a good source of history,” says Ramanathan. He points out that British records such as *Colonel Wells’*

Memoirs, and *Tinnevely Gazetteer* portrayed Kattabomman as a negative character. After Kattabomman’s death, Britishers demolished his fort and exiled his family. Panchalankurichi, where he had ruled, was shown in maps as wasteland (*paazh nilam*). But Kattabomman could not be erased from the minds of the people. Stories and songs about Kattabomman were sung, and koothu about him were enacted across South Tamil Nadu. “The ballads about Kattabomman give us his side of the story and must be included when the history of that period is recorded.”

We learn from ballads that children began studying at the age of five or seven, and get details about what subjects were taught. *Eenamuthu Pandian Kathai* says that when Eenamuthu was nine, he was taught difficult mathematics problems (*kodiya kanakkugala*). He completed his education when he was 13. *Paramasivasivanu Pandiar Kathai* tells us that at age seven a girl studied multiplication tables. From *Pennarasayar Kathai*, we gather that girls were given military training too. Ballads show us that words from other languages made their way into Tamil. Ramanathan says that *kullaara in kullaara vandi* (covered cart) probably came from the Sanskrit word *kulaaya* meaning cage. Savurusangi is the Tamilisation of the Urdu *Jabarjangi* meaning small cannon.



N.C. Srinivasaraghavan

Tied: *The Weaver’s Loom* – a thematic Bharatanatyam production by Sahana Selvaganesh – was a blend of classical vocabulary and contemporary storytelling. The narrative followed a woman in a marriage marked by infidelity and domestic abuse. Forced to leave while pregnant, she raises her child independently. Layered on this was the metaphor of the weaver’s loom – drawing on the imagery from India’s handloom traditions. The performance was at Jharna festival, organised by Bharata Kalanjali.

The presentation referenced weaving through poetry, music and

choreography. It included Kabir’s poems alongside newly composed Sanskrit and Tamil pieces. Though thoughtfully chosen and musically vibrant, the weaving metaphor and the protagonist’s journey did not integrate seamlessly, at times moving on parallel tracks rather than reinforcing each other dramaturgically.

An innovative aspect was the use of props. A cloth figure, representing the husband was adorned with silk-thread jewellery. As the story progressed, the dancer removed each ornament and wore them to symbolise the stages of marital struggle, before discarding them to mark the end of the relationship – adding an experimental, theatrical dimension.

However, the balance between the classical Bharatanatyam

structure and contemporary expression was not struck. In places, adherence to classical vocabulary and musical format seemed to limit the expressive weight demanded by the modern theme. A slight recalibration may have allowed the avant-garde elements to resonate more strongly.

A particularly robust section depicted the weaving process itself. The dancer demonstrated a clear understanding of the craft, translating its physicality into convincing movement within the Bharatanatyam framework. These passages were among the most aesthetically satisfying. T.V. Sukanya’s imaginative violin and sensitive tuning of the compositions, along with Uma Sathyanarayanan’s assured vocal

support, contributed significantly to the presentation’s effectiveness.

Within its one-hour span, the production attempted to encompass multiple aspects of the protagonist’s journey – betrayal, abuse, abandonment, pregnancy, resilience and self-reliance. This structuring, however, meant that many emotional states appeared only briefly, as the narrative moved swiftly from one episode to another. Consequently, the intensity felt somewhat diffused. A more sustained focus on select turning points might have enabled a stronger emotional connection and deepened the work’s impact.

Overall, the work was ambitious, musically and conceptually rich, with moments of striking creativity. The thematic intention was potent and socially relevant.

A different perspective

In *The Abandoned Gopi*, Himanshu Srivastava navigated with ease the symbolic transformation of Shiva into a gopi



Nuanced presentation Himanshu Srivastava. PHOTO: M. SRINATH

for a short solo production was an interesting decision.

One of the strengths of the performance lay in Himanshu’s contrast of Shiva – in his original form and his attempt to assume that of a gopi. The shift was not merely external but suggested a psychological transition, particularly in the enacted exchange between Shiva and Yamuna. The work carried a distinct Vraj flavour, and the depth in preparation was evident in the movement vocabulary and abhinaya.

A notable segment focussed on Shiva’s astonishment at being unable to easily get access to Krishna’s realm, where the Raas Lila unfolds. The exploration – of masculinity and femininity and the space between them – was handled with precision and formed a key aspect of the presentation.

Himanshu’s use of props was effective. The veil marking the transformation into a gopi was visually clear and carried a philosophical suggestion that he chose to articulate.

The production was supported by thoughtful lighting, cohesive musical choices, and structured compositions. His engagement with the material remained steady throughout.

In the concluding segment, he sang while performing seated – introducing a different texture to the piece. Singing, being a separate discipline, added another register to the performance. The technical glitch that it commenced with was resolved at an emotionally apt point, leaving the audience wanting more.

Overall, Himanshu Srivastava emerged as a thoughtful storyteller with a defined approach and consistent engagement with his subject.

Strings and memories

An ensemble conceived by Pt. Ravi Shankar’s wife Sukanya, daughter Anoushka Shankar and disciple Shubhendra Rao revisited his enduring compositions



Pt. Ravi Shankar and Anoushka Shankar. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Shailaja Khanna

Pt. Ravi Shankar turned every raga into a radiant journey, making India’s music resonate on the global stage. To honour his legacy and memory, the Delhi-based Ravi Shankar Centre recently presented its annual festival. The Centre, which was Pt. Ravi Shankar’s home, comes alive during its annual three-day festival. Held outdoors in the aesthetically-designed amphitheatre, the event was an intimate affair for an invited audience.

The highlight of this edition was the Pt. Ravi Shankar ensemble, put together by his wife Sukanya, daughter Anoushka and senior disciple Pt. Shubhendra Rao. The ensemble featured six musicians – sitarist Shubhendra, sarodist Aayush Mohan, violinist Padma Shankar, flautist Ravichandra Kollur, mridangist B.C. Manjunath and tabla artiste Anubrata Chatterji. Starting mid-March, the ensemble will embark on a multi-city tour across the U.S.

Talking about the ensemble, Sukanya said, “It wasn’t easy selecting compositions from Pt. Ravi Shankar’s vast repertoire”.

The 90-minute event started with a recording of the sitarist singing the Sanskrit shloka ‘Guru Brahma, Guru

Vishnu...’ in raag Bhupali. “Guruji had a pitch-perfect voice. When he sang, I would put my sitar down and just listen to him,” recalled Shubhendra.

The ensemble moved on to present a piece on Ganesha and Saraswati. The first piece was in raag Aiman, composed for Pt. Ravi Shankar’s concert at the Kremlin in 1988. It also had violin and flute solo segments, that paved the way for a sitar-sarod jugalbandi in raag Jogeshwari. Padma beautifully rendered his ‘Jaane kaise sapno mein’ (from the 1960 film *Anuradha*).

Raag Manjh Khamach, a significant part of Pt. Ravi Shankar’s music, was an apt choice for the occasion. With the next piece, ‘Fire night’, the evening transitioned into a lively interaction among the mridangam, tabla and kanjira. Panditji was among the first musicians to give prominence to his accompanying percussionists during solo concerts. The event closed with his composition ‘Spring’, based on raag Bahar, from the dance-drama *Ghanashyam*. Each piece seamlessly flowed into the other.

“Working for this ensemble has been an emotional journey for me, bringing back memories of how Panditji created each piece, and my 40-year association with him,” said Shubhendra Rao.

HCL concert

The Music Academy will feature a vocal concert by Malladi Sindhu Rageswari as part of HCL concerts series. The performance will be held on March 2, 6 p.m., at Kasturi Srinivasan Hall. The accompanists are K Gayathri Varenya (violin) and Sreekrishna Ganesh (mridangam).

Gaura purnima at ISKCON

ISKCON Chennai, (ECR) will be organising a series of event as part of the Gaura Purnima, to be celebrated on March 3 at its premises. The day begins at 4.30 a.m. with mangala arati. Guru puja, Srimal Bhagavatam discourse, and rendition of kirtan will form part of the day-long event to conclude at 8.30 p.m.

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1st - Sunday	Dr.Jayanthi Kumaresh Veena - Vadhya Anubhavam	6th - Friday	Dr.Trichy Sankaran Laya Anubhavam
2nd - Monday	Shri Udayalur Kalyanaraman Namasankeerthana Paddathi	7th - Saturday	Shri.Neyveli Santhanagopalan Sahithya Anubhavam
3rd - Tuesday	Dr.S.R.Janakiraman Raga in Kalpana & Kalpita Sangeetha	8th - Sunday	Ms.Leela Samson Natya Anubhavam
4th - Wednesday	Dr.Sriram Parasuram Raga Anubhavam	9th - Monday	Smt.Suguna Purushothaman Niraval
5th - Thursday	Shri.Chitravina N.Ravikiran Sangeetha Anubhavam	10th - Tuesday	Mr.Gnani Sankaran Nataka Anubhavam
Do not miss to watch thought – provoking lectures!			

IndianOil

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THE DUCHESS CLUB

Sunday, 8th March, 8am
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LANGFEST 2026 'HISTORIES IN PLURAL'

DAY 1: SATURDAY, 28TH FEBRUARY

10.00-10.30
Instrumental Music (flute, saxophone, and percussion) at Kanali Mandapam by R S Vikram and K R Keerthi Rathan

10.45-11.00
Inauguration

11.00-11.50
Hot Topic, Cold Facts
Anirudh Kanisetti in conversation with Vaishna Roy

11.50-12.40
Shaping History through Archaeology
Sharadha Srinivasan and Cherian P.J in conversation with Ezhil Madhii

12.40-13.40
Lunch

14.00-14.50
History for Peace
Megha Malhotra and Janaki Nair in conversation with Aunohita Mojumdar

14.50-15.40
The Houses Come Alive
Performances of poetry, dance and more inspired by regional traditions, live at the houses of DakshinaChitra (Ikkat House, Chikmagalur House, Chettinad House and Calicut House)

16.00-16.50
A Slice of History in Films
T J Gnanavel and Sashi Kumar in conversation with Anitha Pottamkulam

17.00-18.00
'Thol' Music Performance by Uru Paanar at the Amphitheatre

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Venue: Seminar Hall, DakshinaChitra Museum, Muttukadu, Chennai

DAY 2: SUNDAY, 1ST MARCH

10.30-11.00
Instrumental Music (flute, saxophone, and percussion) at Kanali Mandapam by R S Vikram and K R Keerthi Rathan

11.00-11.50
Memoir of a Generation - History of the Feminist Movement in India
Urvashi Butalia in conversation with Pulari Meera Baskar

11.50-12.40
Chroniclers of Cities
Sidharth Bhatia, Nandakumar Melethil, and Kombai S Anwar in conversation with Gita Jayaraj

12.40-13.40
Lunch

13.40-14.30
Thamizh Isai - A History yet to be told
Dr. Amutha Pandian and Prof. Balamurugan in conversation with Kutti Revathi

14.30-15.00
Songs of Abraham Pandithar and exposition of Thamizh 'Pann' by students of Tamil Technology Research Center, Bannari Amman Institute of Technology

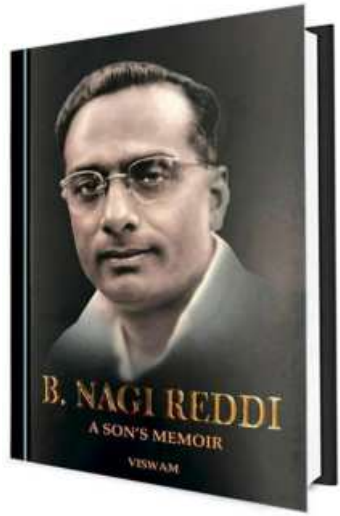
15.00-15.50
Business Histories
Raman Mahadevan and Harish Damodaran in conversation with Dr. Srinivasan Ramani

15.50-16.40
Polyphony Sounds Better
Deepan, Thilagavathi and Rohith Abraham (OfRo) in conversation with Sangeetha Sivakumar

16.50-17.40
Walkthrough of DakshinaChitra Museum

CM YK

M CH-CHE



S.B. Vijaya Mary

In South Indian cinema, a production house once had the power to become an identity. Janaki became Sowcar Janaki after her debut in the film *Shavukaru* (Telugu) under Vijaya Productions, and Nirmala became Vijaya Nirmala after *Enga Veettu Penn* (Tamil). Such was the cinematic significance of the studio B. Nagi Reddi created. His fame came from the unforgettable films he produced and the legacy he left behind.

These and many other anecdotes find mention in *B. Nagi Reddi: A Son's Memoir*, by Viswam (Viswanatha Reddi).

Born in Pottipadu, a village in today's YSR Kadapa district of Andhra Pradesh, Nagi Reddi's journey began far from the arc lights and studios of cinema. Drawn early to India's freedom movement, he later moved to erstwhile Madras to manage the family business, showing a natural flair for enterprise that took him even as far as Rangoon (Burma). He eventually made Vadapalani, in Madras (now Chennai) his professional hub. In time, the area became a vital for the South Indian film industry, and was shaped by his vision for cinema, publishing and healthcare.

The 250-page book by Vijaya Publications offers a peek into the formative years of Telugu and Tamil cinema. It captures



Down memory lane (Clockwise from left) B. Nagi Reddi directing AVM Rajan; A scene from *Enga Veettu Pillai*; Viswam; a still from *Missamma*; and the book cover. PHOTOS: THE HINDU ARCHIVES & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Beyond the arc lights

In *B. Nagi Reddi: A Son's Memoir*, Viswanatha Reddi reveals how his legendary father, who shaped South Indian cinema, was more than a filmmaker



the spirit of what is often called the golden era, tracing the rise of Vijaya Productions and offering a first-hand chronicle of an industry in the making, its visionaries and institutions.

Viswam says that the book is not written as a monument, but as a memory. "I see my father as a gentle, disciplined and deeply private person. These were men who built industries from dust and

created livelihoods for many, yet never sought publicity. My father was one such. I sometimes feel that had they lived in Mumbai or Delhi, history would have deified them. But in the South, they chose dignity over display and let their work speak for them.

From the grandeur of *Patala Bhairavi* and the brilliance of *Mayabazar* to the entertaining social *Missamma*, Nagi Reddi's

Telugu productions defined the grammar of classical Indian cinema. In Telugu, his films with N.T. Rama Rao and Akkineni Nageswara Rao became landmarks, while in Hindi, *Ram aur Shyam* with Dilip Kumar reflected his national reach.

In Tamil cinema, his journey is seen as a bridge built across generations. His collaborations with M.G. Ramachandran remain unmatched in scale and influence, while his partnerships with Sivaji Ganesan, and later with Rajinikanth linked generations of stardom.

When he acquired Vauhini Studios and merged it with Vijaya Studios, he created one of the most powerful studio ecosystems in Indian cinema, where production, training, craft and infrastructure coexisted and strengthened one another as one vision. That

same instinct to build something purposeful outside cinema led him to create Vijaya Hospital and Vijaya Healthcare Centres.

The book also traces the parallel growth of the South Indian film industry and its camaraderie, its ethical competition and its collective spirit. Viswam recalls an era where studios looked out for each another, where producers were genuinely concerned about the well-being of the contemporaries that they competed with, and where growth was seen as a shared experience. His father, Viswam says, constantly supported new entrants, as he felt new voices would keep the industry alive and evolving, and believed that stagnation was the real enemy of cinema.

The memoir is as intimate as it is historical. Viswam writes as a son who once felt hurt that even his own family did not fully realise the extent of his father's contributions. The project took years of gathering voices – colleagues, workers, associates – because he never wanted the story to be told in a single perspective. "We never wanted to narrate a story. We wanted people, who were associated with him, to speak."

The book does not try to magnify the stature of the Dadasaheb Phalke-awardee. Instead, it shows B. Nagi Reddi as a man who built studios and hospitals, who shaped cinema and publishing, and who mentored generations with quiet conviction.

Ye's India calling

Kanye West's polarising persona will take centre stage at his debut concert



Rachel Rhine

After years of being known in India largely as a streaming presence and a recurring subject of online debate, Kanye West – now performing as Ye – will finally perform in India on March 29 at Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium, New Delhi. For an artist whose work has travelled widely without a touring footprint in the country, the announcement feels less overdue than curiously timed. India has only recently become a routine stop on global itineraries, and Ye arrives not as a legacy act revisiting familiar territory but as someone whose

relevance depends on constant reinvention.

Across his catalogue, the shifts are difficult to compress into a single narrative. Early records such as *The College Dropout* were built around soul samples and conversational storytelling; *808s & Heartbreak* redirected mainstream rap toward electronic melancholy; *Yeezus* pared sound down to near abrasion; and *Donda* expanded outward into stadium-scale listening events that blurred release strategy and performance art. What remains consistent is a tendency to treat each album as a reset rather than an extension. The live show typically follows that logic. His concerts rarely

operate as hit parades. They function more as atmospheres built from familiar material, rearranged to suit a specific visual and sonic environment.

For some listeners the draw is the catalogue; for others the hesitation lies in the controversies that surround it. The concert brings those positions into proximity, turning what is usually an online discussion into a collective audience response. Applause, indifference, enthusiasm or restraint become visible rather than abstract, shaped not by individual listening habits but by the dynamics of a crowd. In that sense, the evening functions not only as a performance but as a public negotiation of how

The stage is set For Ye. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

audiences separate, or choose not to separate, the work from the person presenting it.

The booking also says something about how the live circuit is changing. Early international concerts in India relied on artists whose appeal was uncomplicated and widely shared. Recent trends suggest audiences are comfortable approaching artistes associated with a stronger authorial identity, even when that identity invites disagreement. Ye's presence fits that shift. His work generates discussion about intention and method as readily as it does about melody. A stadium audience is therefore not simply gathering for recognition but for interpretation.

How the format translates locally will be worth observing. Large concerts here tend to build around collective participation, the familiar chorus carried by thousands of voices. Ye's staging has often emphasised immersion instead, extended passages of sound and lighting where the crowd listens rather than sings. The difference is subtle but significant. It changes the audience from co-performer to observer, at least intermittently, and asks for attention rather than constant response.

The event will inevitably be read alongside the public image that accompanies him. Yet the more interesting question may be narrower: what it means for an artiste defined by constant reconfiguration to appear in a market still shaping its expectations of live performance. If the evening succeeds, it may not be because every listener leaves satisfied, but because the experience resists easy summary.

CALENDAR



Celebrating a visionary

Kalakshetra Foundation's 'Remembering Rukmini Devi' festival will be held from February 27 to March 1 at Bharata Kalakshetra auditorium and Rukmini Arangam. The festival will feature thematic productions, vocal and instrumental concerts. The curtains go up with 'Andal Charitham', a dance drama by Kalakshetra Foundation on February 27 at 6 p.m. J.A. Jayant's flute recital will be featured on February 28 at 6 p.m. The festival concludes with Sooryagayatri's bhajan rendition at 9.30 a.m. on March 1 and Rajashree Warriar's Bharatanatyam solo in the evening at 6 p.m.



Honour for Aruna

Super Chennai presents the inaugural edition of 'Super Chennai Arattai', on February 28, 5 p.m., at Welcomhotel by ITC Chennai. The first in the series will feature senior Carnatic musician Aruna Sairam. On the occasion, she will be honoured as the Super Chennai Icon of the Month, in recognition of her contribution to music and her role in taking the city's cultural legacy to the world.

Radha kalyanam

Namasankirtanam, rendition of Ashtapadi, Divyanamasankirtanam and unchavritti will form part of the Radha kalyana mahotsavam to be held at Sri Sankara Gurukulam, Abhiramapuram, from today to March 1. Srivanchiyam Murali Bhagavata's namasankirtanam will take place today at 7.30 p.m. Tomorrow O.S. Sundar's rendition of Gita Govindam will be at 8.45 a.m. and dolotsavam will be performed by the members of Sri Gnanananda Mandal at 6 p.m. On March 1, Radha kalyanam will take place at 9 a.m. and Anjaneya utsavam at 6.30 p.m.



Vocal concerts

Hamsadhwani has organised the following vocal concerts at Youth Hostel, Adyar. Schedule: Today, 6.15 p.m.: Shertalai K.N. Renganatha Sharma with Embar Kannan (violin), Arjun Ganesh (mridangam) and Sunil Kumar (kanjira). Tomorrow, 5.15 p.m.: Vaishnavi Ramadass with Sri Lakshmi Bhat (violin) and Palani Balaji (mridangam); 6.45 p.m.: S. Srivatsan with M. Vijay (violin) and Akshay Ananthapadmanabhan (mridangam).



From the archives

A 10-day lecdem series from Paalam's archives will be streamed on www.paalamtv.com from March 1 to 10 at 6.30 p.m.

Schedule: March 1: Jayanthi Kumaresh's lecture will be on 'Veena - Vadhya Anubhavam'. March 2: Udayalur Kalyanaraman – 'Namasankeerthana Paddathi'. March 3: Prof. S.R. Janakiraman's 'Raga in Kalpana and Kalpita Sangeetha'. March 4: Sriram Parasuram's 'Raga Anubhavam'. March 5: Chitravina N. Ravikiran's 'Sangeetha Anubhavam'. March 6: Tiruchi Sankaran on 'Laya Anubhavam'. March 7: Neyveli Santhanagopalan's lecture 'Sahithya Anubhavam'. March 8: Leela Samson's 'Natyana Anubhavam'. March 9: Suguna Purushothaman's lecdem on 'Niraval'. Gnani Sankaran's lecdem 'Nataka Anubhavam' will be streamed on March 10, bringing the 10-day series to a close.

Themed on Purandaradasa

Bombay Gnanam Arts Academy and Mahalakshmi Ladies Drama Group will jointly premiere a Tamil musical *Bhagwan Sri Pandurangani Purandaradasar* on March 2, 6.45 p.m. at Mylapore Fine Arts Club. The play, by Bombay Gnanam, will continue to be staged till March 7. There will also be a special show on March 8, 10 a.m. at the same venue, to mark International Women's day.



Tamil plays

Chromepet Cultural Academy will stage two plays this weekend at its CCA hall. Details: February 28, 6.30 p.m.: Jaya Keerthana Creations' *Sparisam*, written by Ramanan. March 1, 6.30 p.m.: UAA's *Lights on*, written by Venkat.